

ANIMISM

SURREAL ANIMATION

During traditional Chinese festivals and important ceremonies, the custom of shaping various animal figures out of dough is known as noodle moulding. The origin of this custom is closely related to ancient Chinese religious ceremonies, in which people make face moulds to offer sacrifices to gods and ancestors, and to pray for a bountiful harvest, national prosperity, family harmony and prosperity. The story stems from the traditional practice of using face moulds to convey blessings and the Buddhist concept of 'liberation'.

BACKGROUND

Wanwuyouling vs renleizhongxing

Humanity's Faith in All Things – Worship



In the Tibetan region of China, there are very many customs and rituals, among which the famous pilgrimage is a unique religious and cultural tradition, and in them I see the true reverence of human beings for nature. They worship the sacred mountains and lakes as the abode of gods and spirits, and make annual pilgrimages around the mountains and lakes, expressing their respect and prayers for nature by kowtowing to the long head and going round the mountains, believing that these natural landscapes are inhabited by gods and spirits or contain spirituality.

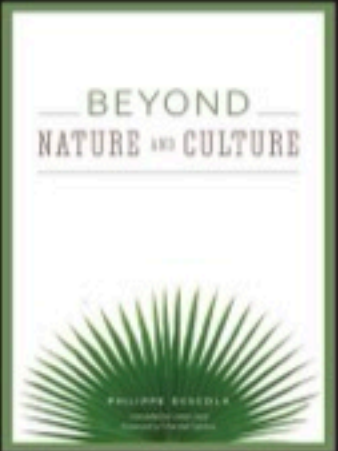
Humanity's Control Over All Things – Exploitation



The Amazon rainforest, known as the ‘lungs of the Earth’, is rich in ecological diversity and a globally important carbon store. By treating natural resources as tools to be used indefinitely for economic gain, human beings have ignored the value of the rainforest as a key part of the global ecosystem. Such short-sighted exploitation reflects a disregard for the right to life in nature, placing human interests above other lives.

《超越自然与文化》（Beyond Nature and Culture）
- 菲利普·德斯科拉

This book delves into the essential differences between animism and anthropocentrism, revealing the ways in which different cultures understand the relationship between nature and humans. Animism believes that everything in nature, such as mountains, rivers and animals, possesses a soul and shares life and emotions with humans, emphasising equality and interconnectedness between humans and nature and focusing on harmonious coexistence. Anthropocentrism, on the other hand, places human beings at the centre of the universe, believes that the significance of nature is to serve human beings, emphasizes the control and use of nature, and embodies human beings' sense of superiority over nature.



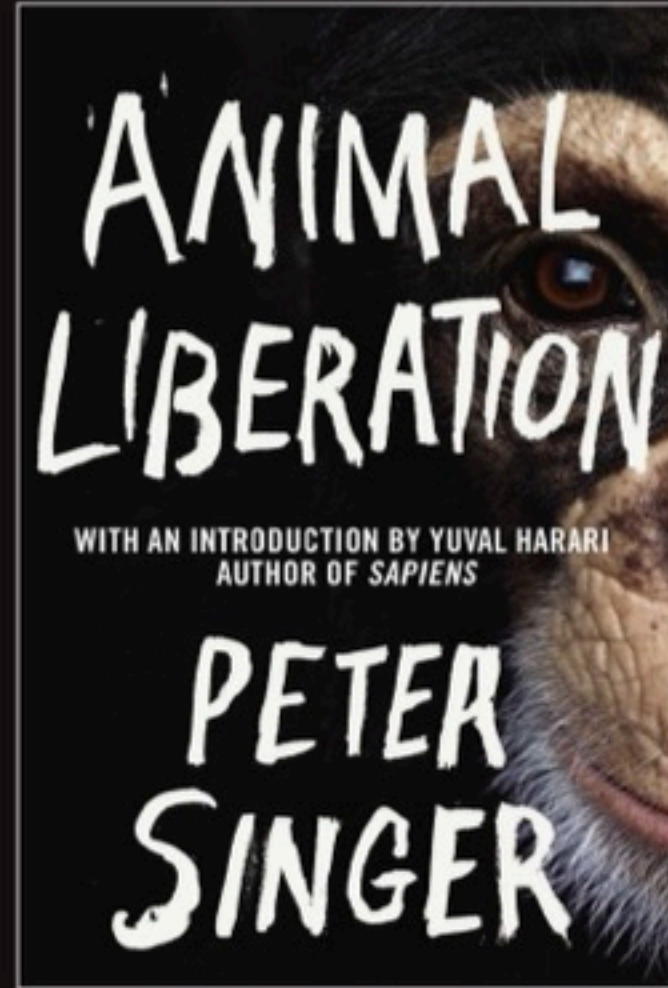
Comparison Summary:

PERSPECTIVE	ANIMISM	ANTHROPOCENTRISM
CULT OBJECT	Natural entities, such as mountains, rivers, and animals.	Deities, ancestors, and heroes related to humanity.
WORSHIP PURPOSE	To seek harmony with nature and express gratitude for its forces.	To fulfil human needs and reinforce social order.
WORSHIP METHODS	Peace, simplicity, and respect for the spirituality of nature.	Involves sacrificing life and reinforcing human authority.
CULTURAL SIGNIFICANCE	Emphasises harmony between humans and nature.	Emphasises humanity's central position in the world.
CONCLUDE	 =   =  Humans and all natural entities co-exist equally, emphasizing respect for life and the spirituality of nature, advocating a worldview of harmonious coexistence.	    Humanity is at the center, with other life forms and nature regarded as mere resources, reflecting an unequal relationship.

It can be seen in the world human beings want to survive must be the need to fear nature, to all things to have a sense of reverence, from ancient times to the present day is still the case, only with the survival of all things in harmony, human beings can survive for a long time, but nowadays I also see that there are a lot of the opposite phenomenon, they show the phenomenon in my opinion excessive anthropocentrism.

RESEARCH

Research to support the above viewpoint



《动物解放》（Animal Liberation）– 彼得·辛格Peter Singer

Presentation of proposals against 'speciesism'

In his book, Peter Singer criticises 'speciesism' - i.e. prejudice based on species, similar to racism or sexism. He argues that it reflects an anthropocentric attitude that humans are morally superior to other species and should prioritise their own interests.

He suggests that all beings capable of perceiving pain should be treated with equal moral care, and that respecting the value of life in other species is an important step in building a just society.

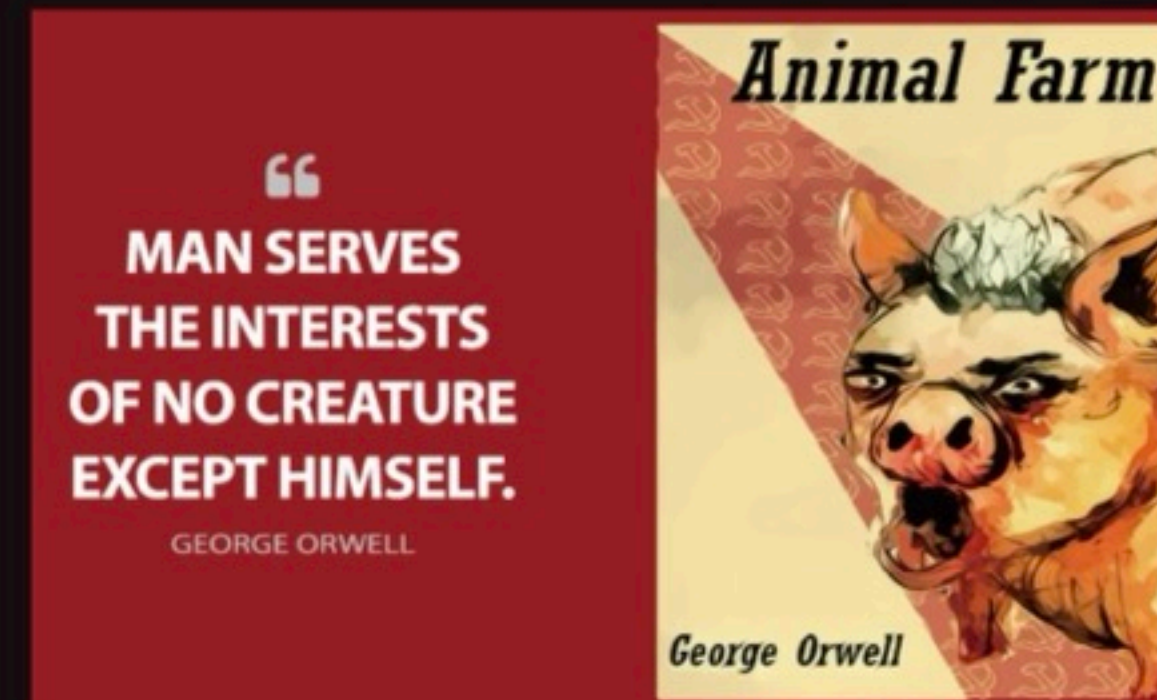


Spanish documentary "Fauna 2023"

Animal experiments in nature

The film shows the struggle of herders in the face of the decline of nature and tradition, as well as the busy scenes of science and technology in the laboratory for vaccine research and development, revealing that while technological development improves the quality of human life, it also poses new challenges to the ethics and value of life.

The real "progress" may not be simply relying on technology, but learning how to live in harmony with nature and cherish the diversity of life.



George Orwell's *Animal Farm*

The Irony of Utopia

George Orwell's novel *Animal Farm*, through the story of anthropomorphized animals rebelling against human domination in an attempt to establish an egalitarian society, exposes the issues inherent in anthropocentrism.

Is our attitude towards other beings really just exploiting them? Perhaps equality is not just for human society, but should also include respect for other species.



Patricia Piccinini (Australian artist)



The Diversity and Interconnection of Life

Patricia Piccinini is known for her surrealist sculptures, which often combine the forms of humans, animals and machines to explore the diversity and boundaries of life. Through the delicate depiction of hybrid biological forms, she expresses her deep thinking about life and her interpretation of the concept of "animism".

Her work made me realize that every form of life has its own unique value, and the relationship between humans, nature and technology should be more humble and respectful. This concern for the equality of life inspired me to think about the ethical boundaries of technological development, and at the same time made me reflect on whether we have truly accepted "difference".

STARTING POINT

My Story

The Chinese Han cultural tradition of dough sculpture is renowned, and I experienced it many times during my childhood, leaving a deep impression on me. I chose to incorporate my personal story to convey the core message because the cultural characteristics I felt through this tradition reflect not only its artistic value but also many societal phenomena.



Personal experience

Dough figurines appeared in many festivals when I was a child. All the family members would make dough figurines together. It would be more interesting to add personal creativity and imitation. Then, during the sacrifice process, we would express our emotions and spiritual needs through dough figurines to pray for the ancestors and God.

what is dough sculpture?

The origin of dough modeling can be traced back to ancient China thousands of years ago. It is a traditional Chinese folk art form, also known as "dough figurines" or "dough flowers". It uses basic materials such as flour and water and, through multiple processes, creates very vivid and lifelike images of animals, flowers, and other natural and mythological characters.

what does dough sculpture signify?

In China, Dough Sculptures are often featured in traditional festivals, temple fairs, and folklore events, primarily serving as offerings to gods and ancestors for worship and prayers, transforming them into a medium for expressing emotions and fulfilling spiritual needs.



Why do I want to reflect animism through Dough Sculpture?

I believe in animism and therefore see dough sculpture as having a soul. By imitating the forms of other living beings, humans create dough sculptures to fulfil emotional and spiritual needs, often neglecting the intrinsic value of other life forms.

WORKING PROCESS

Animation content storytelling

This is the storyline of an animated work, inspired by the Chinese tradition of dough sculpture and traditional sacrificial festivals. *The narrative unfolds in four stages, progressively deepening in meaning.* Through experimental animation, it satirises human behaviours and phenomena, provoking thought and reflection.



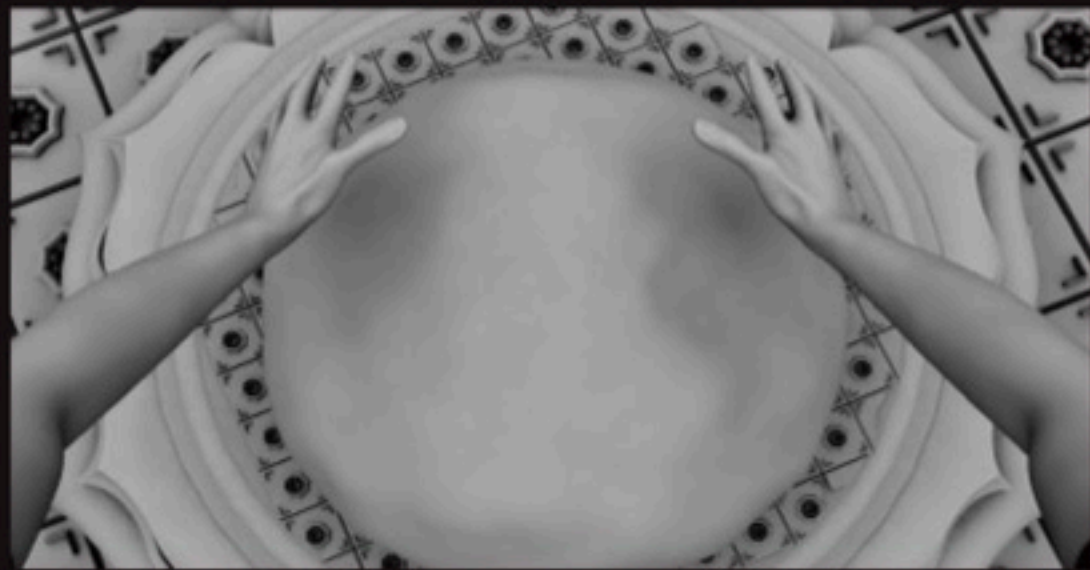
1. Ritual preparation - offering

The story takes place in an ancient oriental village where the mysterious 'Dough Soul Ceremony' is held annually. In front of the ancestral hall stands a massive altar, where villagers are busily preparing for the festival's main ritual. With solemn reverence, they offer Dough Sculptures infused with the essence of animal souls as sacrifices to their ancestors and gods.



3. Ritual climax - creation

Suddenly, the souls within the dough figurines and dough began to manifest, their cries of agony reverberating through the shrine. Each soul represented a trapped animal desperately struggling to escape the prison of the dough. The dough artisan and villagers were struck with shock and horror as they watched their creations come to life in such a terrifying and unnatural way.



2. Ritual commencement - creation

As the ceremony officially begins, the dough artisan starts crafting the dough using traditional techniques. However, as the dough gradually takes shape, he hears a faint purring sound emanating from it. He soon realizes that the dough is no ordinary material—it is imbued with the souls of animals.



4. Ritual conclusion - rupture

As the dough crumbles, centuries of tradition disintegrate. The freed souls ascend to the heavens, and cracks begin to form in the shrine's revered elephant idol. With the souls redeemed, the villagers are left with a profound sense of awe for the unknown future and the mysteries of life.

Production process



Made using C4D

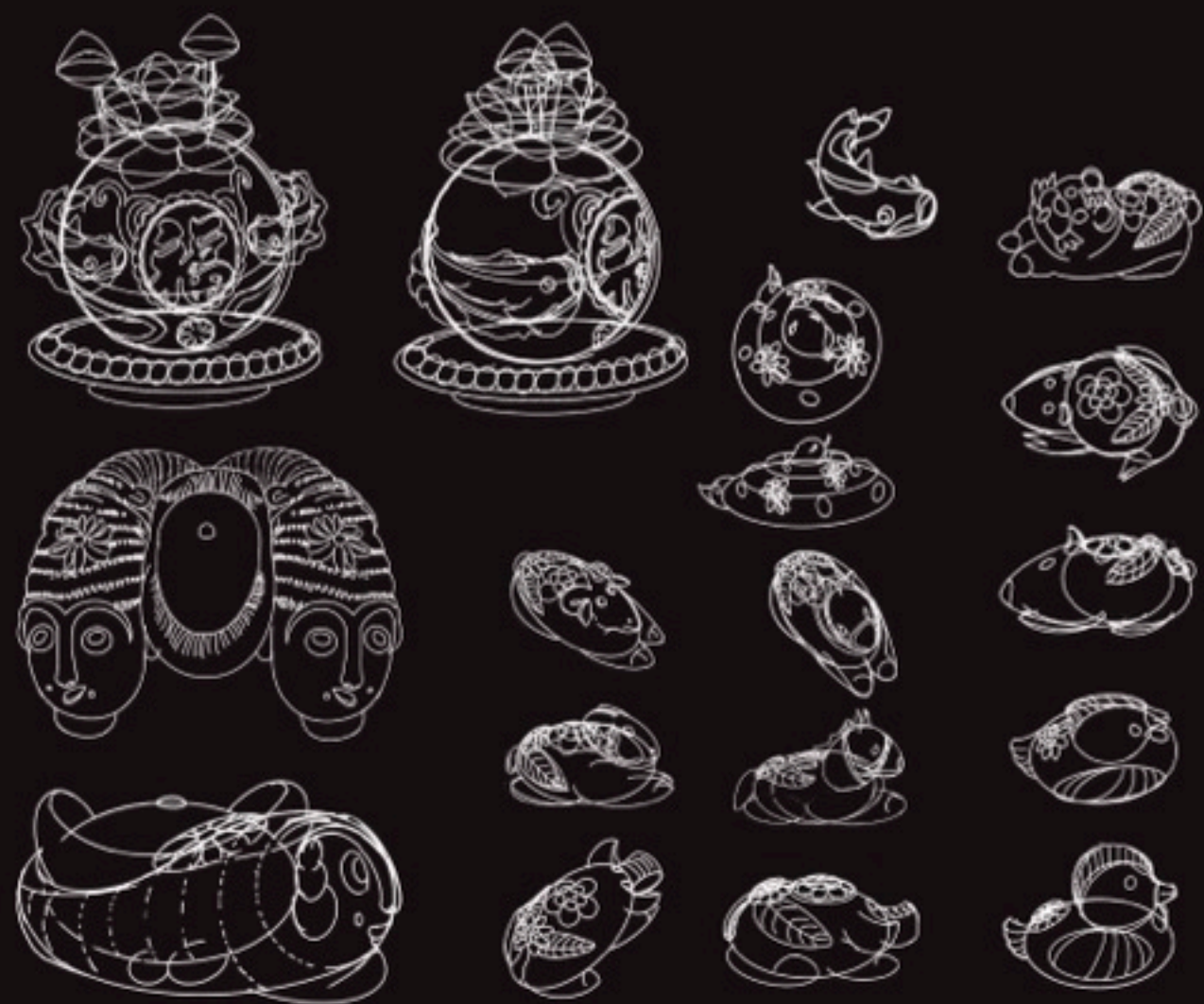
This 3D animation, created entirely in Cinema 4D, centers on traditional dough sculpture rituals and anthropocentrism. The scene design focuses on a sacrificial ceremony, incorporating large stone statues, dough-sculpted animals, and participant arrangements to evoke a strong religious atmosphere. Key symbolic details, such as the dough animals and statues, highlight traditional culture. Through the narrative of "releasing animal souls," the work explores humanity's control over and misunderstanding of nature.

OUTCOME

Animation core design

Center Reference:

I drew three-dimensional surface sculpture manuscripts from multiple angles with reference to the solid surface sculpture images, mainly animals and decorations. This is an important reference for me in making 3D models.



OUTCOME

Panoramic display

Video: <https://d578dv.58u.cn/a/b1PXraP/>

Affective expression:

Humanity is not the center of the world, and the meaning of life goes far beyond the values we assign to it. Every frame of animation, every scene, is a projection of my emotions—a gesture of gratitude to nature, a respect for life, and a challenge to anthropocentrism. I hope this work not only conveys a sense of solemnity and mystery but also allows the audience to feel that indescribable connection between all things. It is both an expression of my beliefs and my most sincere tribute to the world.



OUTCOME

Details Show



From the ancient village to the villagers' ritual ceremonies, the entire scene is not merely a recreation of traditional customs but a reflection on anthropocentrism. The crafting of dough sculptures, their ritual offering, and the moment when the animal spirits struggle to break free all carry my contemplation of the essence of life. As the spirits are released from the dough sculptures and ascend to the sky, they break age-old traditions and challenge humanity's subjective definitions of life. I believe that only by recognising the spirituality of all things can humanity coexist harmoniously with nature.

OUTCOME

The background is a vibrant sunset sky with soft, wispy clouds in shades of orange, pink, and purple. A bright sun is visible on the left side, creating a lens flare effect. Floating in the sky are several dark, oval-shaped objects that resemble planets or moons. Interspersed among these are small, translucent dough sculptures of various animals, including a bird, a frog, and a turtle. The overall composition is dreamlike and artistic.

In the end, this story challenges the anthropocentric perspective embedded in traditional customs, calling for a reevaluation of the relationship between humans and nature. By releasing the animal souls trapped within the dough sculptures, it conveys the interconnectedness of all life and advocates for viewing other beings with respect and empathy, fostering a more harmonious relationship with the natural world.